

Two Unproven Effects Do Not Average to One Proven Effect: Cold Fusion and Antigravity Hybrid Claims

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Abstract

A recurring subgenre of fringe physics literature proposes that low-energy nuclear reactions, popularly known as cold fusion, produce as a byproduct or side effect a local reduction in gravitational weight, sometimes framed through an appeal to exotic nuclear or lattice-confinement processes said to alter the local mass-energy density in a manner that couples to gravitation. This paper argues that combining two independently unestablished claims does not strengthen either one, that the specific mechanism proposed, a coupling between anomalous nuclear heat production and gravitational weight, has no basis in the (already contested) cold fusion literature itself, and that the appeal of the hybrid claim rests on borrowing the more mainstream-adjacent legitimacy of ongoing low-energy nuclear reaction research to lend credibility to a gravitational claim that research has never made.

1 Introduction

Since the 1989 Fleischmann-Pons announcement of apparent excess heat from electrolysis of heavy water using palladium electrodes, low-energy nuclear reaction research has continued as a small, largely marginalized field, with proponents pointing to occasional excess-heat measurements as evidence of an unrecognized nuclear process, and the broader physics community remaining unconvinced, citing failed replications, the absence of expected nuclear reaction products such as neutrons or gamma rays in the quantities a nuclear process would require, and persistent difficulty ruling out mundane calorimetric error. A further, smaller subset of this literature layers a gravitational claim on top of the excess-heat claim, proposing that the same unspecified process reduces the weight of the reacting apparatus or of nearby objects.

2 Why the Excess-Heat Claim Provides No Support for a Gravitational Claim

Even granting, for the sake of argument, that some genuine anomalous heat production occurs in these experiments, an anomalous heat source is not evidence of a gravitational effect unless an independent mechanism links the two, and no such mechanism is specified in this literature beyond the observation that both are, individually, unexplained. Two unexplained phenomena occurring in the same apparatus at the same time are not evidence that they share a cause; they are, in the absence of a specified linking mechanism, exactly as likely to be two separate errors, or one error and one non-effect, as they are to be a single underlying discovery. The hybrid claim's persuasive force comes from proximity rather than argument: an apparatus already associated with one contested claim of anomalous physics is treated as more hospitable ground for a second, unrelated one.

3 Mass-Energy Coupling Does Not Work the Way the Hybrid Claim Requires

Some versions of this claim invoke mass-energy equivalence directly, proposing that a reaction releasing energy correspondingly reduces the reacting material's mass, and that this mass reduction manifests as reduced weight in a manner disproportionate to the actual energy released. Mass-energy equivalence is real and well confirmed, but the mass defect associated with even the largest plausible (and highly disputed) excess-heat claims in this literature, computed via $E = mc^2$, is many, many orders of magnitude too small to produce any measurable weight change, since converting even a substantial fraction of a gram of matter to energy releases an amount of energy vastly larger than any reported cold fusion excess-heat measurement, meaning the actual mass defect involved in these experiments, if the excess heat is real at all, is undetectably small and cannot be the source of any macroscopically observed weight reduction.

4 The Entropic Gravity Framing

On an account of gravitation as the geometric bookkeeping of a large-scale ordered configuration's redistribution, a localized, small-scale nuclear or lattice process, however anomalous its heat output might be, does not represent a redistribution at anything like the scale required to register as measurable curvature, independent of and in addition to the mass-energy equivalence argument above. Both the standard and the entropic account agree that whatever is or is not happening inside a palladium electrode, it is not happening at a scale that could plausibly touch gravitation.

5 Objections

Proponents occasionally argue that the relevant coupling is not through simple mass-energy equivalence but through some exotic nuclear or lattice-confinement effect not captured by standard theory, analogous to the appeal made by other devices surveyed in this series to unspecified subtle fields. As with those cases, an appeal to an unspecified mechanism is not an argument for a mechanism, and the burden of specifying and testing it remains with the claim, a burden the cold fusion antigravity literature has not, in over three decades, discharged.

6 Conclusion

Layering a gravitational claim onto an already contested excess-heat claim does not strengthen either, since no specified mechanism links the two beyond the fact that both remain unexplained by mainstream theory, and the mass-energy magnitudes involved in even the most generous reading of the underlying excess-heat literature are far too small to produce any measurable gravitational effect under either the standard or the entropic account of gravitation.